Redemptive Narratives are Contagious

Personal memories of hardship become more redemptive after reading others' stories

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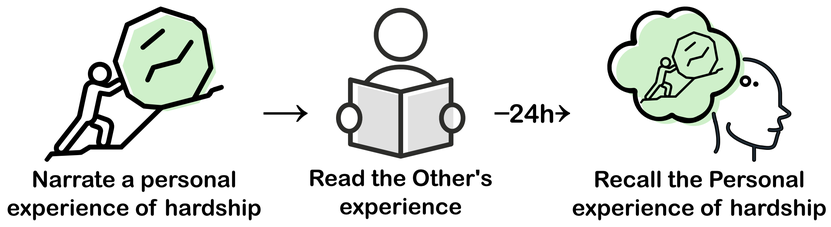
Background

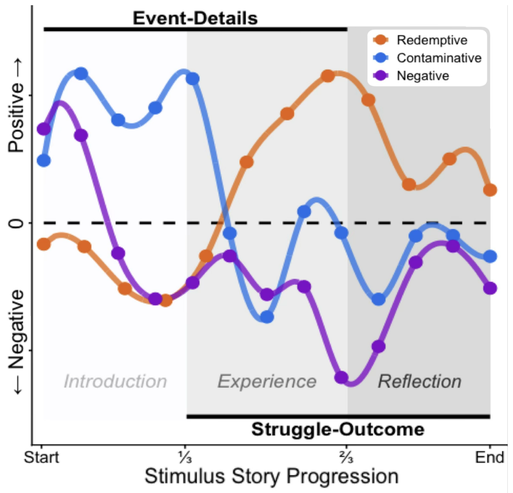
Redemption is a common literary arc found in everyday storytelling[1]. Literature also links redemption in our autobiographical experiences to better mental health and well-being[2,3]. Here, we ask if we adopt redemptive arcs over other narratives (e.g., tragic) when recalling our own experiences of hardship, and which individual measures modulate this adoption of a redemptive affective structure.

Design & Analysis

A nationally representative sample (n=159) of Young and Middle-Aged adults (18-45 years old) **narrate an experience of hardship**.

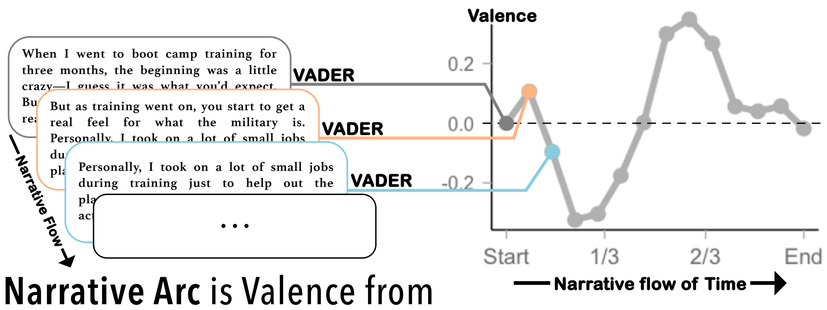


Participants then read one of three consistent stories: Redemptive, Contaminative/tragic or Negative.



24 hrs later, the participants return to recall their own personal narratives.

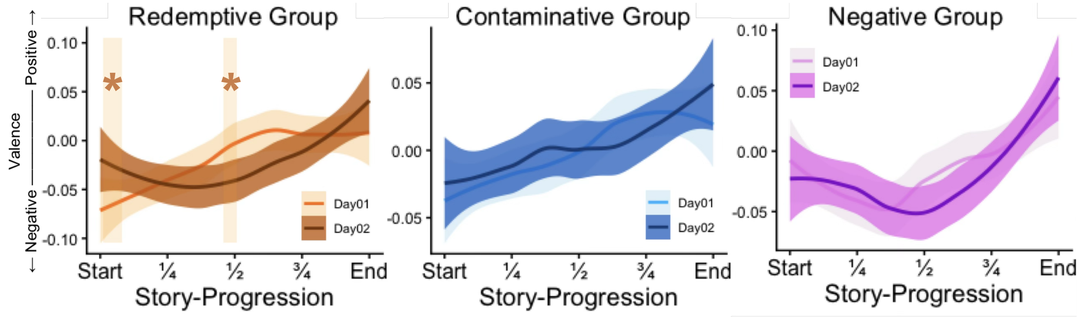
On the left, is the stimulus *Narrative Arc*, as divided into 3 paragraphs.

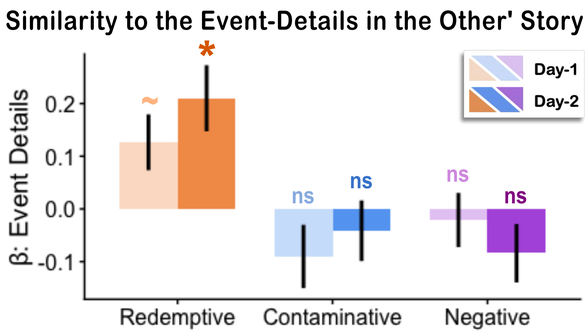


Narrative Arc is Valence from 2-sentence SW with overlap, derived using VADER.[4]

Narrative Structures

Personal narrative arcs of the **Redemptive group** differ significantly on Day-2. The plot (right) shows within-participant difference, correcting for multiple comparisons ($p<.016$).





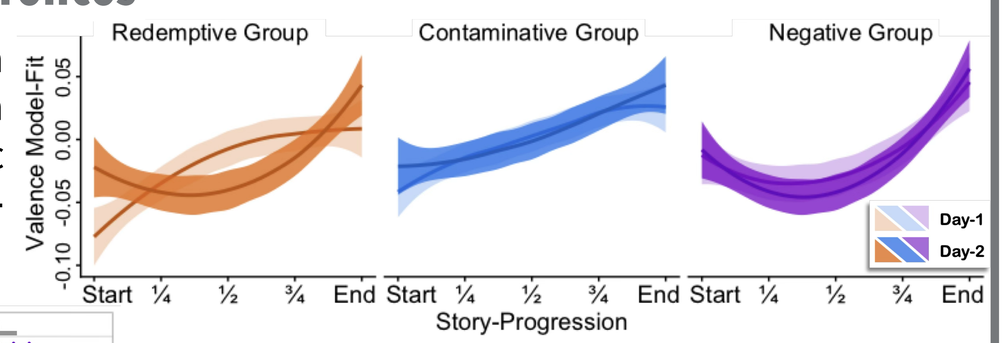
Participants' personal narratives are not influenced by the valence of entire story (p's$>.29$). We don't find group-level differences in their Day-1 stories' similarity to the Other's Redemptive story.

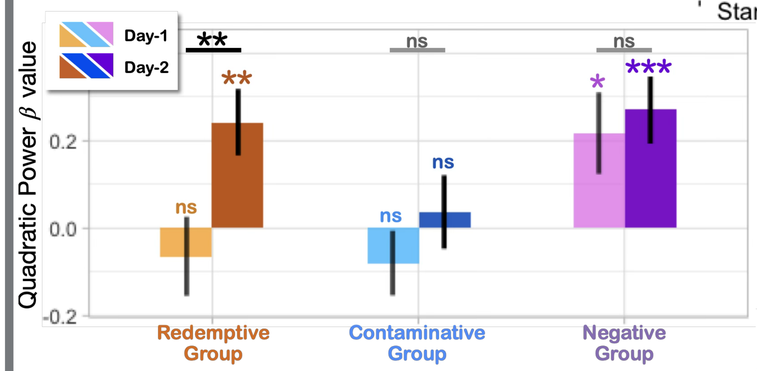
Personal narrative arcs become more similar to the event-details in the story the participants read on Day-2 for the **Redemptive group** ($t_{\beta}(53)=3.35$, $p=.0014$), but not other groups (p's$>.13$).

The Event-similarity effect persists when controlling for Day-1 similarity, but only for participants who read the Redemptive story ($\beta=0.18$; $CI_{95\%}=[0.07 - 0.28]$; $p=.002$).

Models and Individual Differences

Individual narrative arcs are fitted to an additive polynomial model, based on the best-fit model (Linear and Quadratic powers) to the arc resembling the **Event-Details of the Redemptive story**.

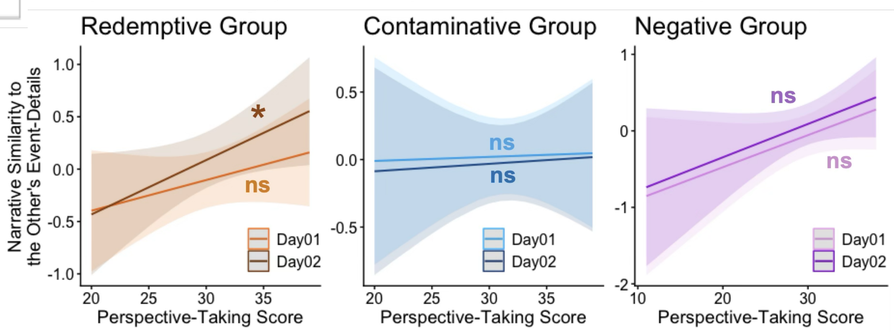




On Day-2, the readers of the **Redemptive story** show significantly greater quadratic-like curving of their narratives than Day-1 ($p_{Day\text{-}2}<.01$; $p_{change}<.01$; left).

Random assignment collected the redemptive narrators in the Negative Group; our next study aims to explore resilience in redemptive stories.

High perspective takers also show a greater tendency to adopt the **Redemptive Arc** of the Other's events on Day-2 ($\beta=0.26$; $CI_{95\%}=[0.02 - 0.53]$; $p=.02$), but they do not similarly adopt the other Arcs (p's$>.13$).



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Read the Stories...

We designed the stories using Generative LLMs and some in-house authors who gladly volunteered to review and edit the work to make them more believable.

Redemptive Story
Contaminative Story (Tragic)
Negative Story (Pessimistic)

References

1. McAdams, 2006; *Am. Psyc Assoc.*
2. Rogers et al., 2023; *J.Pers & Soc Psyc*
3. Speer et al., 2021; *Nature-Comm.*
4. Hutto & Gilbert, 2014; *AAAI*.

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